

**Northern Highlands Regional High School Home and School Association, Inc., (HASA) minutes of the general meeting held on September 16<sup>th</sup>, 2015.**

**Present at Meeting:** Margaret Engkvist, Gloria Dreyer, Christy Soell, Michele Madonna-Scherreik, Glee Rogers, Maria DiMartino, Renee Buzzelli, Belinda Alward, Tracy Platt, Terry Madonna, Dana Sileo, Barbara Garand, Sheila Yallowitz, Christine Ferrarie, Sheryne Brekus, Fidelis Feeley-Corrie, Ariana DeLucia, Lisa Tantillo, Grace Valente, Sharon Holle, Bob Pash, Louise Basralian, Cathy Squasoni, Elaine Peebles, Sue Hynes, Mary Ellen Moschetta, Kathy Travers, Nancy Levin, Gina Grieco, Josephine Nirchio, Nancy Tarbutton, Jean Holden, Maria Abrahamsen, Lisa Ceccon, Andrea Pennington, Stacy Paton

**Staff Present at Meeting:** Dr. Scot Beckerman, Mr. Joe Occhino, Mr. Michael Koth, Ms. Kelly Peterfriend

President Stacy Paton called the meeting to order at 9:34 AM and began our first order of business which was introducing our new Superintendent, Dr. Scot Beckerman.

**Superintendent's Report – Dr. Scot Beckerman:** Dr. Beckerman thanked the HASA board for the Back to School Night Dinner we provided to the staff. He informed the group that he has a conflict and cannot attend the HASA Sponsored Freshman Parent Breakfast. Dr. Beckerman is spearheading the district's strategic planning process. The development of a 3-5 year strategic plan will begin on 1/20 and the key areas of focus are the state of the school, vision and dreams, and goals and destinies. The plan will cover facilities, academics and co-curricula's and the team will reflect on how to improve all three and implement a new and improved vision. The Strategic Planning team is looking for input from parents. The parents will be included in 3 planning meetings to be held on 1/20/16, 2/11/16 and 3/23/16. All sessions will be held in the auditorium at 7:00PM. Any interested parties should contact Dr. Beckerman with their contact information and you do not need to attend all 3 dates to participate. Dr. Beckerman also mentioned that there will be an electives audit. The purpose of this audit is to assess where we are with electives currently and delineate where we want to be moving forward. There will also be a student super forum. This Forum will be to get feedback from students at all levels and find out directly from them what Highlands does well and what we can improve on in the future. The superintendent's office is currently working on a district newsletter to be disseminated at a future date.

**Principal's Report – Mr. Occhino:** Mr. Occhino thanked everyone at Highlands for facilitating a great school year opening. Mr. Occhino mentioned that this past summer the summer assignments were revamped. The staff wanted to continue to focus on student wellness and they eased up on the summer assignments. He solicited feedback from the parents at the meeting with regard to this change. Most families loved the change noting that there was less stress between parents and their children over the summer due to the fact that they didn't have to pressure their kids to do their summer assignments. Parents did mention that maybe they could find a happy medium with regard to "summer slide" as many kids didn't do any reading at all this summer. Suggestions included reading a community book with no written assignment attached, suggested summer reading list – pick one book to read of the students' choice, college essay assignment for seniors.

Mr. Occhino explained that there were 5 major assessments to assess students in the past. There was a unit test after each unit, a project based assessment and a research based assessment. This year they will shift in what they are doing for assessments. There will be 9 assessments instead so teachers can

assess what is necessary sooner and that will drive changes in instruction. General announcements made by Mr. Occhino were that the 8<sup>th</sup> grade visitation to the school is usually held earlier, but it had been changed to accommodate the 50<sup>th</sup> Anniversary celebration. PARCC results will be coming in late October or early November. The results from these tests will impact the graduation class of 2020, which is one year later than previously discussed. The Transition Project will be held on 9/18. This program is an outreach program with student ambassadors reaching out to freshmen. This program has been in existence for 10 years. This program has been very successful and helps freshmen feel at home and not looked down upon by upper classmen. The ambassadors help get the freshmen acclimated to the high school environment. Lastly, we are very proud of our Honor Roll Students. 563 students will be attending our Honor Roll Breakfast to be held on 9/17 at 7:15AM.

**Vice Principal's Report – Mr. Koth:** Mr. Koth announced that the 50<sup>th</sup> Anniversary Celebration will be on 9/26 at 11AM. Events will include an alumni open house, guided tours, and a varsity football game at 2:30PM. Former alumni, parents and staff are all invited for a complimentary BBQ as an additional part of the festivities. Please RSVP if you will be attending the BBQ at [constancebanstra@gmail.com](mailto:constancebanstra@gmail.com). "We can't wait to showcase our top rate programs, facilities, academics and great students at the celebration," he noted. Another exciting program coming soon is NHRS will host an assembly with FBI Director James Comey, a former 1978 Northern Highlands graduate. We will have a town hall style meeting and will get questions from the students for a Q & A for the meeting.

**School Counseling/Guidance Report – Ms. Peterfreund:** Elective changes deadline has passed. The students can still change academic placement at this time. All program dates are on the school counseling/guidance website. The school counselors have met with seniors and all new students. Important dates of interest include 9/17 College Fair at FDU. Bring return address labels to put on cards to fill out at the fair. 10/1 is the *First Step a 9<sup>th</sup> grade program including Naviance* which will be held in the auditorium at 7PM. Ms. Peterfreund also announced that guidance has addresses on social media. Follow them on Twitter at @NHGuidance and on Instagram. Mr. Occhino has a Twitter account as well. Follow him at @occhinoj on Twitter. The counselors will be going out to visit some California campuses soon. Reminders have been sent out to all seniors regarding deadlines for applications, written essays and teacher recommendations. A question was asked if Guidance would ever sponsor overnight trips to see college campuses. The response was that it would be too hard to coordinate at this time.

**Board of Education Report – Jill Webb:** Jill, Barbara Garand and Sheila Yallowitz are in attendance and are happy to be working with Dr. Scot Beckerman. The Board is happy to announce that there was a lot of facilities work done over the summer. They had a new heating/air conditioning unit installed in the Science Wing, new carpeting, and a new roof installed. Highlands has updated our wireless capabilities so we will be able to roll out our PC initiative next year successfully. Surface 3 computers will be utilized with 95% of the classes and will be keeping 3-5% of other options such as MAC's.

**MPAA – Christy Soell:** There will be a band competition coming up on 9/19 at 4:00PM on the field. We will be having a Wine Tasting Fundraiser at \$40.00 per person. 7 wines will be tasted with appetizers. The fundraiser will be held on October 14<sup>th</sup>. The November Fall play is in rehearsals now. The MPAA welcomes people to come attend their monthly meetings on the 2<sup>nd</sup> Monday of every month.

**Sports Association – Bob Pash:** The Sports Association is happy to announce that they have donated 4 portable, environmentally friendly lights to the BOE for use at NHRS. The lights will provide better light coverage for the athletes and students using the field. The new lights are expected to come within a few weeks. The lights cost over \$300,000. 80% of the funds are completed. The rest will have to be funded through a letter of credit unless we meet our goals through fundraising. The Sports Association is running a fundraising paver program for all communities. This program is a great way to preserve your family name. Please spread the word to help us light the dream. The portable lights can also be repurposed throughout the campus to other locations so all programs can use them. Also, membership forms are available to join the Sports Association. These funds that are acquired through membership help pay for additional things for the athletic programs at Highlands.

**HASA President – Stacy Paton:** Introduction of new members to the board. Encouraged everyone to attend the Freshman Parent Breakfast. Thanks to Nancy Levin for the refreshments for the meeting. Sign-up sheet for breakfast donations disseminated. Anyone signing up for refreshments will be reimbursed. Overview of what HASA provides to the school included - Planners for all students, Freshman Transition Project, Equipment for TV Studio, Planetarium movies, Speakers and more. Stacy extended thank you's to membership team, Louise Basralian for the coordination of the Freshman Breakfast, Christine Ferrarie for the HASA newsletter and Constant Contact emails and Sue Hynes for the website.

**Treasurer's Report – Kathy Travers:** Kathy provided report and mentioned that we would be saving money next year by NOT paying for planners. An App will be provided through our new computer initiative next year for a planner.

**Grocery Card Chairperson – Andrea Pennington:** Shop Rite, Stop and Shop and Fairway cards available today and flyers are available to send in orders.

**Membership – Christy Soell and Michele Madonna:** Please hand in your membership forms. We have 395 members to date.

**Secretary – Andrea Pennington:** Motion was made to approve minutes from June 2015 meeting – Ariana DeLucia. Gloria Dreyer seconded the motion.

Next meeting was announced for 10/14. Bob Williams is set to attend and present on the activities and athletics/clubs offered. Board was asked if they could post minutes from the meetings on the HASA website. The board will look into it. Meeting was adjourned.

Respectfully submitted,

Andrea Pennington – Recording Secretary